

Android-powered shoes for the visually impaired!

Enter *Le Chal* ('Take me there' in Hindi), the Android-powered shoes that offer unobtrusive navigation for the visually impaired! In a path-breaking innovation, Anirudh Sharma, an IT engineer from Rajasthan Technical University, has designed these unique shoes, which are connected to an Android device that helps navigate them using Google Maps and the phone's in-built GPS.

Anirudh's brainchild was showcased at the MIT (Massachusetts Institute of Technology) Media Lab Design and Innovation Workshop 2011.

Le Chal is equipped with vibrators, proximity sensors and a Bluetooth pad, which is connected to an Android device. The Android phone figures out directions and real-time locations using Google Maps and the phone's in-built GPS and compass module. To use the shoes, the user needs to voice the end location, before starting the journey. The Android app then works on defining the route map, calculating turn-by-turn directions, which are sent to the shoe via Bluetooth, mentions a report. Then different vibrators positioned in the shoes are activated to give feedback to the user, depending on the turn she or he needs to take. In short, the technology turns navigation data into haptic feedback.



Obama gets petition to end software patents



A recent petition, according to the 'We the People Project' of the White House, has asked the administration to end software patents. The petition has been signed by 14,000 people, and asks the Obama administration, "To return sanity to the software industry—one of the few industries still going strong in America—direct the patent office to cease issuing software patents, and to void all previously issued software patents."

Quentin Palfrey, from the White House office of the CTO, responded saying, "As an Administration, we recognise the tremendous value of open source innovation, and rely on it to accomplish key missions. For example, the U.S. Open Government National Action Plan recently announced that the source code for 'We the People' and Data.gov would be open-sourced for the entire world..."

ICFOSS to launch Android R&D in Trivandrum

The International Centre for Free & Open Source Software (ICFOSS) is all set to gear up research and development (R&D) activities on the popular smart-device platform, Android. ICFOSS has been awarded a composite project by the Department of Information Technology (DIT), Government of India, which can help it in this initiative.

The project includes support for Indian language localisation,



Sony's Music Unlimited available for Android tabs

Now, Sony joins the list of online music providers for Android tablet PCs, along with Spotify, MOG, Rdio, and Rhapsody. Sony's Music Unlimited is available in the US, France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, Spain, the UK, Australia and New Zealand.

Two types of monthly subscriptions are available: \$3.99 for the basic and \$9.99 for the premium version. Music Unlimited version 1.2 is compatible with the Sony Tablet S. Sony is offering a 30-day free trial for its music services.



Sabayon releases four Linux 7 Core editions

The latest core editions of version 7 of Sabayon Linux are SpinBase, CoreCDX, ServerBase and OpenVZ.

The Core editions are a derivative of the Sabayon 7 release, which is based on the 3.0 Linux kernel. The SpinBase edition is aimed at home server deployment. The CoreCDX edition includes Fluxbox, a minimalist X window manager, which allows users to customise Linux according to their needs. ServerBase is powered by a server-optimised Linux kernel, and the OpenVZ edition is the project's official virtualisation template. The Core editions are available for download on both 32- and 64-bit systems.

